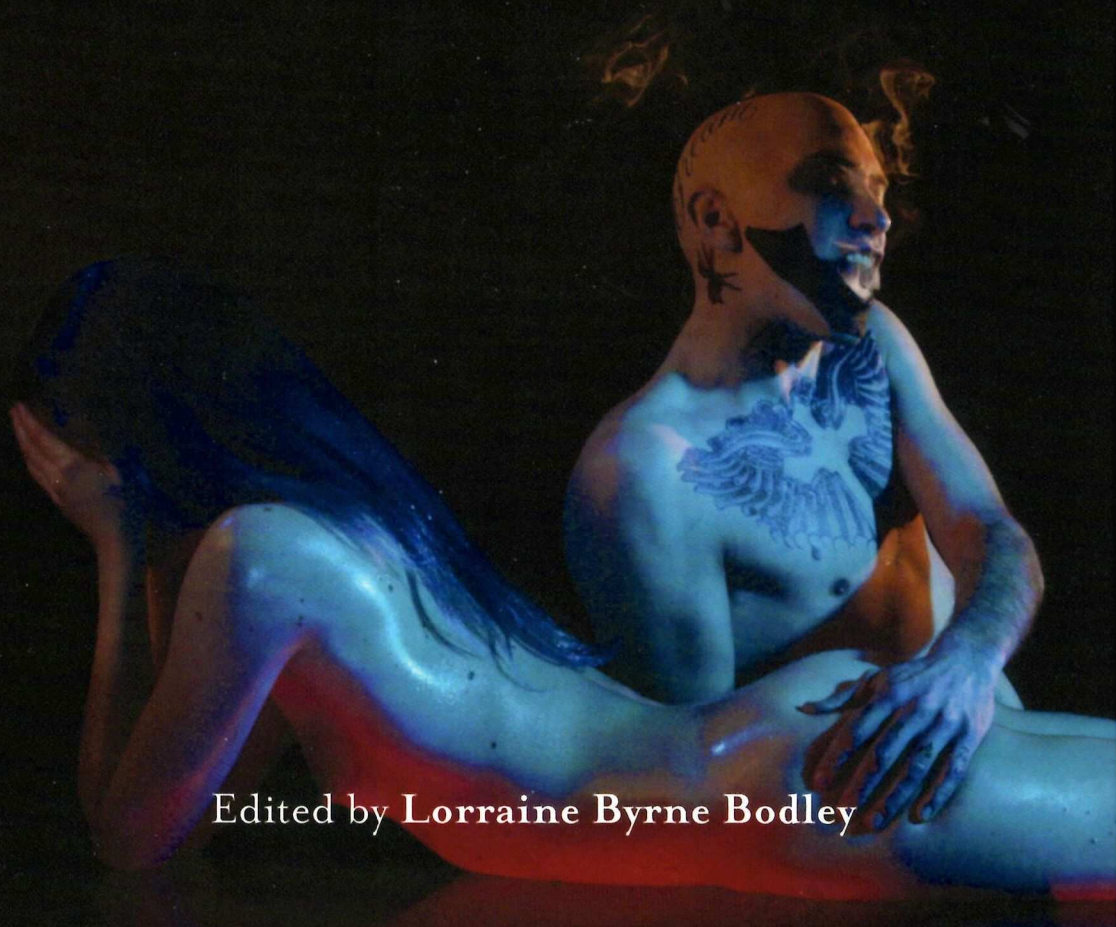


MUSIC IN GOETHE'S *FAUST*

Goethe's *Faust*
in Music



Edited by **Lorraine Byrne Bodley**

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THE BOYDELL PRESS

Linking Christian and Faustian Utopias

Mahler's Setting of the Schlußszene in his Eighth Symphony

Eftychia Papanikolaou

Upon its publication, Goethe's *Faust II* met with perplexing reception as to its generic classification and complex narrative. Writers who boldly proposed an allegorical interpretation also reflected on its resistance to traditional stage presentation. Robert Schumann, who set to music scenes from both Parts I and II of *Faust*, made Faust the protagonist of his oratorio *Szenen aus Goethes Faust* (1844–53). Franz Liszt's setting of the 'Chorus mysticus' at the end of his *Faust-Symphonie* (1854) represented an unconventional response to Goethe's text.¹ But it was not until Gustav Mahler's Eighth Symphony (1906) that the *Schlußszene* from *Faust II* received an admittedly monumental treatment. By setting to music the parts of *Faust II* that were rarely set to music, Mahler made redemption – with all its interpretative baggage – the epicentre and eventual apogee of his work.

Mahler set the First Part of the Eighth Symphony to the Latin Pentecost hymn *Veni creator spiritus* ('Come Holy Ghost, Creator'),² while the Second Part comprises an exalted melopoiesis of the final scene of Part II of Goethe's *Faust*. The setting of the sacred hymn *Veni creator spiritus* abounds in secular musical references (band music and marches, with subtle allusions to sacred music), whereas

- 1 Liszt famously eschewed a programmatic illustration of the story of *Faust* in music. Instead of narrating the plot instrumentally, Liszt opted for a depiction and, subsequently, interpretation of the three main characters of the drama. Each of the three movements (Faust, Gretchen, Mephistopheles) offers a separate musical gloss on the characters and their relationships, through the manipulation of the thematic ideas. Mephistopheles is primarily portrayed through the dislocated and parodied themes associated with Faust, whereas Gretchen's themes remain essentially intact. Liszt emphasized Mephistopheles' powerlessness at the end by ending the Symphony with a true moment of apotheosis: a setting of the Chorus mysticus, sung by a tenor soloist and men's chorus, built primarily on Gretchen's themes from the second movement – after all, she partakes of Faust's salvation at the end.
- 2 See detailed discussion in Christian Wildhagen, 'The "Greatest" and the "Most Personal": The Eighth Symphony and *Das Lied von der Erde*', in *The Cambridge Companion to Mahler*, ed. Jeremy Barham (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 128–35.

Goethe's secular text is clothed in music of unmistakably religious character. The protagonist's struggle and the drama's mystical message of redemption seem to have resonated with the composer, as revealed in the genesis of the work and subsequent interpretations gleaned from his correspondence. Like Goethe's *Faust*, the Eighth traverses the genre's boundaries, and its musical ethos defies generic expectations. By sculpting the text in the mould of a symphony, Mahler upholds – and simultaneously critiques – the prevailing tradition of the venerable symphonic genre. At the same time, the Eighth reinforces perceptions of universality and authority appropriate to a setting of *Faust*, while it also offers a musical analogue to its ambivalent and multivalent status as a genre.

From Goethe to Mahler

Goethe subtitled *Faust* 'eine Tragödie', but, as Dieter Borchmeyer has put it, 'If *Faust* is a tragedy, it is one despite Faust himself'.³ Bluntly put, *Faust* was no Aristotelian tragedy and the mixing of styles (which alluded to Shakespearean tragedy and also Dante) was amplified by the lack of suffering detected in the protagonist.⁴ Jane Brown and others have defended the assertion that Faust is not representative of the tragic hero – he does not suffer. Instead of catharsis, the drama's conclusion proceeds exactly in the opposite direction: as a 'Christian drama of salvation'. In the words of Borchmeyer, 'the devil never had a chance to begin with'.⁵

Earlier in the nineteenth century, before the publication of *Faust II*, few would have foreseen – let alone accepted – the hero's eventual salvation. The widespread image that Faust had acquired among contemporary critics was that of an immoral character. Wolfgang Menzel, Goethe's notoriously vitriolic critic, humorously proclaimed that 'if Faust deserved salvation after destroying Gretchen and her family, then every pig that rolls in a flower-bed deserves to be the gardener'.⁶ Faust, at that time, was no hero of the German nation and *Faust II* represented an immoral 'subversion of the Faust legend'.⁷

The dramatis personae of the *Schlusszene* – holy Anchorites, church fathers, penitent women and the Mater Gloriosa – make overt allusions to Christianity. It would be misleading, however, either to interpret the last scene on strict

3 Dieter Borchmeyer, 'Faust Beyond Tragedy: Hidden Comedy, Covert Opera', in *Goethe's 'Faust': Theatre of Modernity*, ed. Hans Schulte, John Noyes and Pia Kleber (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011), 209–34 (here 210).

4 See, among others, Jane K. Brown's thorough treatment in *Goethe's 'Faust': The German Tragedy* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1986). As Nicholas Boyle suggests in the conclusion of his essay in this volume, Faust may not be a hero, but Goethe's *Faust* is a 'tragedy, perhaps the tragedy, of modernity'. Nicholas Boyle, 'Wagering on Modernity: Goethe's Eighteenth-Century Faust', 60.

5 Borchmeyer, 'Beyond Tragedy', 211.

6 Cited in *Faust, Part Two*, trans. David Luke (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998), lxxix; original in Wolfgang Menzel, 'Faustiana', *Literaturblatt* 47 (6 May 1833), 187; also in Wolfgang Leppmann, *The German Image of Goethe* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1961), 60, n. 2.

7 Brown, *German Tragedy*, 256.

theological terms or to read in Goethe's theology any kind of dogmatic approach.⁸ Goethe was born a Lutheran, but his hostility toward institutional Christianity became a pervasive stance throughout his life and career, as the author's biographer Nicholas Boyle has shown.⁹ Numerous explanations have been proposed to explain Faust's redemption. For some, Faust does not seem to desire salvation; it is rather *offered* to him through the mediation of Gretchen, who exemplifies Goethe's notion of 'divine grace'. This concept, that striving will not bring salvation without divine intercession, has puzzled many critics who read in it a quintessentially Catholic theology. Goethe himself wrote the lines 'Wer immer strebend sich bemüht, Den können wir erlösen' in quotation marks in his manuscript and he considered them to be the essence of *Faust*. In an often-quoted conversation that Eckermann reported from 6 June 1831, Goethe noted that

In diesen Versen [...] ist der Schlüssel zu Fausts Rettung enthalten. In Faust selber eine immer höhere und einere Tätigkeit bis ans Ende, und von oben die ihm zu Hilfe kommende ewige Liebe. Es steht dieses mit unserer religiösen Vorstellung durchaus in Harmonie, nach welcher wir nicht bloß durch eigene Kraft selig werden, sondern durch die hinzukommende göttliche Gnade.¹⁰

[In these lines [...] is contained the key to Faust's salvation. In Faust himself there is an activity that becomes constantly higher and purer to the end, and from above there is eternal love coming to his aid. This harmonizes perfectly with our religious views, according to which we can obtain heavenly bliss, not through our own strength alone, but with the assistance of divine grace.]

In other words, Christianity provided Goethe 'a richly resonant and above all a familiar corpus of iconography and doctrine'.¹¹ It is as such that the religious allegory of *Faust II* has been viewed by scholars and commentators – as a philosophical rather than a theological belief system.¹² After all, religious imagery, as Carl Niekerk has observed, 'functions as a tool and is not to be confused with the message of the text'.¹³

8 Goethe's religious outlook is summarized in H.B. Nisbet, 'Religion and Philosophy', in *The Cambridge Companion to Goethe*, ed. Lesley Sharpe (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002), 219–31. Regarding the religious elements in *Faust* see Osman Durrani, *Faust and the Bible: A Study of Goethe's Use of Scriptural Allusions and Christian Religious Motifs in Faust I and II* (Bern: Lang, 1977).

9 See Nicholas Boyle, '"Theology": Gods, Goddesses and Wilhelm Meisters Lehrjahre in Goethe's Religious Development', in *Goethe: Musical Poet, Musical Catalyst*, ed. Lorraine Byrne [Bodley] (Dublin: Carysfort Press, 2004), 225–41.

10 Goethe, *Gespräche mit Eckermann*, ed. Ernst Beutler (Zürich: Artemis, 1948), 504; trans. John Oxenford as *Conversations of Goethe with Eckermann* (New York: Da Capo, 1998), 413–14.

11 John R. Williams, *Goethe's Faust* (London: Allen and Unwin, 1987), 36.

12 For further discussion see Jens Malte Fischer, *Gustav Mahler*, trans. Stewart Spencer (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2011), 405–6.

13 Carl Niekerk, 'Mahler's Goethe', *The Musical Quarterly* 89 (2006), 237–72 (here 251).

Speculation about whether Mahler had Goethe's *Faust* in mind from the start of the composition has not met with concrete evidence. Mahler arrived at his summer house in Maiernigg early in the summer of 1906, with plans to dedicate the first part of his vacation time to the revision of the Seventh Symphony. His plans changed immediately, however. As he wrote in a letter to Alma four years later, 'the Spiritus creator took hold of me, shaking me and scourging me for eight weeks, until the main part was finished'.¹⁴ The outcome was one of the most idiosyncratic works both in Mahler's output and in symphonic literature.¹⁵ Mahler had used the human voice in three of his previous symphonies – the Second, Third and Fourth – but this time he decided to create an entirely choral Symphony scored for three choirs, a children's chorus, eight soloists and an orchestra that included celesta, mandolin and organ. He remarked in a now famous letter to the Dutch conductor Willem Mengelberg: 'Es ist das Größte, was ich bis jetzt gemacht. Und so eigenartig in Inhalt und Form, dass sich darüber gar nicht schreiben läßt. Denken Sie sich, daß das Universum zu tönen und zu klingen beginnt. Es sind nicht mehr menschliche Stimmen, sondern Planeten und Sonnen, welche kreisen' [It is the greatest thing I have done so far. And [it is] so peculiar in content and form that it is impossible to write about it. Just imagine that the universe is beginning to sound and to ring. It is no longer human voices, but circling planets and suns].¹⁶

Goethe had made a translation of the *Veni creator* hymn (in Weimar, dated 10 April 1820),¹⁷ though it is doubtful that Mahler knew of it in 1906. He would have concurred with Goethe's description of the hymn, however, as an 'appeal to the Genius' – an 'Appel an's Genie', as he called it in his 'Maximen und Reflexionen'.¹⁸ Mahler owned a complete edition of Goethe's works, and is known to have memorized several passages of the work. As Henry-Louis de La Grange argues, the choice of the *Faust* text must have come easily to him, since Goethe 'had always been one of his literary gods'.¹⁹

The image of Mahler being moved and challenged by Goethe's *Faust* has been problematized further by Carl Niekerk, whose insightful exploration of the text's political and cultural implications within Mahler's milieu provides

14 Letter of 8 June 1910, cited in Henry-Louis de La Grange, *Gustav Mahler* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999), vol. 3, 426–7.

15 *Mahler's Unknown Letters*, ed. Herta Blaukopf, trans. Richard Stokes (Boston: Northeastern University Press, 1986), 54.

16 Gustav Mahler, *Briefe 1879–1911*, ed. Herta Blaukopf (Vienna and Hamburg: Zsolnay, 1982), 360; English translation in *Mahler: His Life, Work and World*, ed. Kurt and Herta Blaukopf (London: Thames and Hudson, 1992), 194.

17 For details see de La Grange, *Gustav Mahler*, vol. 3, 892, n. 18. Evidence might show that Mahler was not actually aware of Goethe's translation at the time of the composition.

18 'Maximen und Reflexionen', in *Goethe's Werke. Vollständige Ausgabe letzter Hand* (Stuttgart and Tübingen: J.G. Cotta, 1833), vols 49, 50 and 64.

19 Henry-Louis de La Grange, 'The Eighth: Exception or Crowning Achievement?' in *A 'Mass' for the Masses: Proceedings of the Mahler VIII Symposium, Amsterdam 1988*, ed. Eveline Nikkels and Robert Becqué (Rijswijk: Nijgh and Van Ditmar Universitair, 1992), 131–44 (here 134).

a new context for the appeal of Goethe's drama for Mahler.²⁰ The reception of *Faust* changed considerably over the nineteenth century and seemed to coincide with the ambivalent attitude toward Goethe's image.²¹ Faust moved from being viewed negatively (and the term 'Faustian' carrying pejorative connotations) to emerging as a tragic character, a demonic figure and even a national hero. Tracing the different aesthetic, political, psychological and other interpretations that the figure of Faust and the term 'Faustian' acquired over time can provide enlightening contextualization.²² The turning point came after 1871 and, as Niekerk emphasizes, 'Mahler's Eighth participated in a rehabilitation of Goethe that had been set into motion by the unification of Germany, even though the text remained controversial'.²³ Despite his 'striking' choice of text, which for Niekerk denotes the composer's insightful approach as a 'literary and cultural historian', Mahler responded to Goethe's drama in a very personal way.

The drama's mystical message of redemption seems to have resonated with the composer since the work's inception. Two preliminary titled outlines Mahler drafted together with some music sketches have survived, though only through secondary sources.²⁴ These 'programmes' seem to have acted as scaffolding that enabled him to ground his creation; later he withdrew every bit of support and adhered to the two-part scheme of the work. Both confirm, however, Mahler's association of the hymn with Faust and with religious imagery: I. *Hymn Veni Creator*; II. *Scherzo*; III. *Adagio Caritas*; IV. *Hymn: die Geburt des Eros*. The second outline is slightly modified: I. *Veni creator*; II. *Caritas*; III. *Weihnachtsspiele mit dem Kindlein* [Christmas games with the little child]; IV. *Schöpfung durch Eros, Hymne* [Creation through Eros, Hymn].²⁵

On the now lost second programme he also reportedly noted, according to de La Grange: '8th Symphony, August 1906; The first idea [*Einfall*], kept for my Almschl. Spiritus creator'.²⁶ The ideas of the hymn's Creator Spirit, Mahler himself as an artist-creator and Alma as the ultimate creator (both sensual, as the object of his Eros, and spiritual, as the Eternal-Feminine exemplified in Goethe's text), intertwine in Mahler's symphonic design and help establish the spiritual unity of the two parts of the Symphony.

20 Carl Niekerk, 'Mahler's Goethe', 237–72. See also his *Reading Mahler: German Culture and Jewish Identity in Fin-de-siècle Vienna* (Rochester, NY: Camden House, 2010).

21 For a thorough treatment see Leppmann, *German Image*.

22 Hans Schwerte, *Faust und das Faustische. Ein Kapitel deutscher Ideologie* (Stuttgart: Klett, 1962).

23 Niekerk, 'Mahler's Goethe', 240.

24 The first programme is reported by Paul Bekker in his *Gustav Mahlers Sinfonien* (Berlin: Schuster & Loeffler, 1921), 273. For the second programme, which also included the opening twenty-eight measures of the *Veni creator* music, see de La Grange, *Gustav Mahler*, vol. 3, 889.

25 For more on the programmes see Christian Wildhagen, *Die Achte Symphonie von Gustav Mahler: Konzeption einer universalen Symphonik* (Frankfurt a. M.: Lang, 2000).

26 de La Grange, *Gustav Mahler*, vol. 3, 890.

Schlußszene

The Second Part of the Eighth Symphony is the longest single movement Mahler ever wrote, and – with some notable exceptions – it constitutes a line-by-line melopoiesis of the last 267 lines of *Faust II*. The musical unity that Mahler accomplishes between the two movements of the Eighth compensates for the vastness of this expansive work. One might even say that, both in its concrete materiality (the repetitious and associative use of the thematic material) and temporal vastness (the entire work exceeds eighty minutes in performance time), the Eighth symbolically reflects the duality of the Faustian condition – needing ‘visceral contact with materiality’ while also seeking ‘abstraction, reflectivity, discursivity’, as Martin Swales asserts elsewhere in this volume.²⁷ Numerous instances of intertextuality unite the world of the *Schlußszene* with the invocation of the *creator spiritus* of Part I. The Angels’ famous lines,

Gerettet ist das edle Glied
Der Geisterwelt vom Bösen,
‘Wer immer strebend sich bemüht,
Den können wir erlösen’ (ll. 11,934–7; bars 384–402²⁸)

[This worthy member of the spirit world
is rescued from the devil:
‘for him whose striving never ceases
we can provide redemption’]

do not receive a particularly musical emphasis by Mahler. There is a striking musical connection, however, between the thematic idea of the Angels (Example 11.1) and the theme most prominently used in Part I of the Symphony to highlight the text’s invocation of the Holy Spirit: ‘accende lumen sensibus, infunde amorem cordibus’ [kindle our sense with light, pour Thy love into our hearts] (Example 11.2). In this instance the music seems to connect Faust’s salvation with the life-giving light of the Holy Spirit. In that sense, the imperative nature of the hymn’s entreaty (‘accende’, ‘infunde’) has been subsumed into the redemptive power of Faust’s striving.

Example 11.1 Mahler, *Symphony no. 8, Part II: Chor der Engel*, ‘Gerettet’, bars 384–9.

Allegro deciso (Im Anfang noch nicht eilen)

Ge - ret - tet ist das ed - le Glied der Gei - ster - welt vom Bö - sen

27 Martin Swales, ‘Reflectivity, Music and the Modern Condition: Thoughts on Goethe’s *Faust*’, 66.

28 Bar numbers refer to the first edition of the full score: *Achte Symphonie von Gustav Mahler* (Wien, Leipzig, Universal Edition, 1911).

Example 11.2 Mahler, *Symphony no. 8, Part I*: 'Accende lumen sensibus' (chorus I and II, bars 261–5).

Mit plötzlichem Aufschwung
Tempo I. subito

ff Ac - cen - de ac - cen - de lu - men sen - si - bus lu

Similarly, Gretchen's final supplication to the Mater Dolorosa is replete with echoes from the opening hymn. The ascending motivic idea at 'er ahnet kaum das frische Leben, / so gleicht er schon der heiligen Schar' [but when he senses there is new life here / he soon will be the peer of any angel] (Example 11.3) prominently repeats music that formed the second part of the first strophe of *Veni creator spiritus*, 'imple [mentes] superna gratia, quae tu creasti pectora' [fill [our souls] with grace, Thou, that didst create them] (Example 11.4).

Example 11.3 Mahler, *Symphony no. 8, Part II*: 'Una Poenitentium', 'Neue kaum', bars 1212–1219.

Nicht schleppen

Neu - e kaum ge - wahr er ah - net kaum das fri - sche Le - ben,
so gleicht er schon der heil' - gen Schar

Consequently, the grace that derives from the Holy Spirit and the grace that the Mater Gloriosa is asked to bestow upon Faust's immortal part both intersect musically and correspond semantically. At the culmination of her plea,

Vergönne mir, ihn zu belehren,
Noch blendet ihn der neue Tag (II. 12,092–3; bars 1235–43; Example 11.5)

[Grant me permission to instruct him –
he is still dazzled by the strange new light]

Gretchen's agonizing sigh gestures make an overt allusion to the 'superna gratia' choral reiteration of Part I (Example 11.6). Whereas in Part I this music culminates in a triumphant E flat major, Gretchen's final cry for salvation articulates a

Example 11.4 Mahler, *Symphony no. 8, Part I: 'Imple [mentes] superna gratia'* (solo soprano, bars 46–54).

A tempo Einwas (aber unmerklich) gemäßigster, immer sehr fließend
dolce espress.

Soprano

Im - ple su - per - na - gra - ti - a, gra - ti - a,

Orchestra

p

S.

quae - tu - cre - a - - sti.

Orch.

pp

Example 11.5 Mahler, *Symphony no. 8, Part II: 'Una Poenitentum', 'Vergönne mir', bars 1235–43.*

kraft! Ver - gön - ne mir, ihn zu be - leh - ren! Noch blen - det - - blen - det -

ihm - - - der - - - neu - - - e - Tag.

cresc.

f

Example 11.6 Mahler, *Symphony no. 8, Part I: 'superna gratia'* (chorus I and II, soprano, bars 118–21).

ff

su - per - na, su - per - na, su - per - na gra - ti

solitary plea in the dominant, B flat major. The earlier appeal to the Holy Spirit for celestial grace finds a tentative resolution in Gretchen's entreaty.

With the entrance of Doctor Marianus, the highest Father in the heavenly hierarchy, the musical setting intensifies the work's aspirations toward theatricality. In a 'rapturous' prayer, Doctor Marianus addresses the Mater Gloriosa, the 'Höchste Herrscherin der Welt' [highest mistress of the firmament] (bars 639ff), who appears for the first time 'floating into view'. Mahler marks her wordless arrival in b. 780 with a four-note theme that anticipates the so-called 'ewig' motif from the 'Chorus mysticus' (Examples 11.7a and 11.7b). This thematic idea is akin to the 'Ewigkeit' motif discussed by Stephen Hefling in the context of Mahler's Symphony no. 2 and *Das Lied von der Erde*. In Hefling's words, this motif symbolizes 'temporal transcendence, and [...] ascent to a realm of peace and nurturance, such as the sphere of "das Ewig-Weibliche"'.²⁹ Thus this instance of motivic appropriation by the orchestra at the sight of the Mater Gloriosa denotes a moment of identification with the allusive Eternal-Feminine of the drama's peroration.

Shared by chorus and orchestra, the repetition of the 'ewig' motif in the music creates an aural tapestry that amplifies the collective petition for mercy. Gretchen

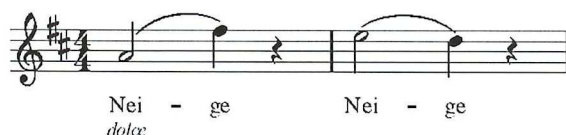
Example 11.7a Mahler, *Symphony no. 8, Part II: 'Ewig' motif* (violins, bars 780–81).



Example 11.7b Mahler, *Symphony no. 8, Part II: 'Chorus mysticus'* (chorus I and II, bars 1486–7).

29 Stephen E. Hefling, *Mahler: 'Das Lied von der Erde'* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000), 12. See also Henry-Louis de La Grange, 'Music about Music in Mahler: Reminiscences, Allusions, or Quotations?', in *Mahler Studies*, ed. *idem* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997), 143.

Example 11.8 Mahler, *Symphony no. 8, Part II: 'Una Poenitentium', 'Neige, neige', bars 1104–5.*



appears as *Una Poenitentium* (bars 1206ff), and her intercession on Faust's behalf suggests a Penitent's joyful view of eternity ('*Neige, neige*', l. 12,069, Example 11.8). The opening musical gesture, however, consists of a transformed echo of the 'ewig' musical idea. Gretchen may be an agent for Faust's salvation, but she speaks in the musical language of the *Mater Gloriosa*, who is the ultimate source of salvation – and thus of *Ewigkeit*.

Having appeared on high like a *dea ex machina*, the *Mater Gloriosa* now sings her only two lines in the entire work, accompanied with a halo of instrumental iterations of the 'ewig' motif. In twenty-four measures of shimmering melodic elegance, she grants Gretchen's request:

Komm! Hebe dich zu höhern Sphären!
Wenn er dich ahnet, folgt er nach (ll. 12,094–5; bars 1249–73)

[Come, rise to higher spheres –
Sensing your presence, he will follow!].

Doctor Marianus, bowing in adoration, has the last monologue in the drama. His 'Blicket auf', a prayer of gratitude, becomes an urgent exclamation in the voices of the chorus. Indicated as *hymnenartig* on the score, the tone is strongly reminiscent of a *Sanctus* in its persistent repetition and celebratory treatment. Mahler describes Doctor Marianus's supplication as 'zart aber innig' (b. 1291), a hushed prayer that also carries with it a musical prolepsis of the 'Chorus mysticus' chorale that will follow. The same melody was earlier prefigured in the music that introduced *Pater Ecstasticus*, culminating in an abbreviated vocal concretization of the theme (bars 227–33). Here orchestra and soloist combine in a nexus of fragmentary motivic exchanges (bars 1305–13) whose profile looks forward to the drama's *dénouement*.

In its last communal address, the chorus hails *Mater Gloriosa* as 'Virgin, Mother, Queen, and Goddess', epithets that encapsulate the multi-faceted female figure that Goethe has explored in its various emanations throughout the drama. The section ends in a serene *pianissimo* B flat major, a suitable dominant for the hushed E flat major that will open the concluding chorus.

'Chorus mysticus'

The final eight lines of *Faust* constitute some of the most often discussed, sibylline passages in world literature:

Alles Vergängliche
ist nur ein Gleichnis;
das Unzulängliche,
hier wird's Ereignis;
das Unbeschreibliche,
hier ist es getan;
das Ewig-Weibliche
zieht uns hinan.

All that is transitory
is but a parable;
The unattainable
is here attained;
The indescribable,
here is accomplished;
The Eternal-Feminine
draws us on high.³⁰

In a conversation with Eckermann, Goethe ostensibly admitted that the familiar theological language from the Christian Church served to give his drama 'Form und Festigkeit' [form and substance],³¹ rather than a strictly Christian outlook. Thus 'Das Unbeschreibliche' is a luminous locus of completion and realization, replete with religious echoes, irrespective of any particular theological tropes.

Mahler clothes the text of the 'Chorus mysticus' in sounds analogous to the text's transcendental imagery. An invisible chorus of disembodied voices pronounces an apostrophe – its message of fulfilment, arrival and accomplishment addresses *us* while it also reflects back on the drama. The solemnity of the moment cannot be lost on the audience, especially with the musical emphasis on plagal cadences, *pianissimo* dynamics, the return to the opening's E flat major and the use of chorale topos (Example 11.9). Mahler's setting of the 'Chorus mysticus' as a chorale, first as a hushed prayer and later in a massively exultant, communal assertion, ideally reflects the sense of arrival, and captures the spirit of mysticism and heavenly imagery to which the text alludes. The 'ewig' reiterations disclose more than just their semantic meaning: 'ewig' becomes a metaphor for transcendence. The venerable chorale style ideally intensifies the *religioso* topos and serves as a fitting peroration of a metaphysical quest where, to paraphrase another writer, Mahler links 'Christian and Faustian Utopias'.³²

That Mahler considered the religious implications of the text when he composed the second part of the Eighth is not only manifest in the exalted musical setting but also in a number of his writings. Two letters that Mahler wrote to his wife Alma in the summer of 1909 reveal important insights about his vision of *Faust*. In June of 1909 he received a letter from Alma in which she had quoted the last four lines of the 'Chorus mysticus'. Mahler wrote back offering a personal reading of the passage, one that emphasizes the unspeakability and inexpressibility of the words:

The eternal-feminine has drawn us on – we have arrived – we are at rest – we possess what on earth we could only strive and struggle for. Christians call this

30 Adapted from Walter Arndt's translation of *Faust*, ed. by Cyrus Hamlin, trans. by Walter Arndt (New York: Norton, 1976), 308.

31 Johann Peter Eckermann, *Gespräche mit Goethe in den letzten Jahren seines Lebens*, ed. Christoph Michel (Frankfurt a. M.: Deutscher Klassiker Verlag, 1999), 489. Translation in *Conversations*, 414.

32 Phrase by Clytus Gottwald in his 'Mahlers Achte', as cited in de La Grange, *Gustav Mahler*, vol. 3, 907.

Example 11.9 Mahler, *Symphony no. 8*, Part II: 'Chorus mysticus', bars 1449–58.

♩ wie früher ♩ Sehr langsam beginnend

ppp (wie ein Hauch)

Soprano
Alto
Tenor
Bass
Orchestra

Al - les Ver - gäng - li - che ist nur ein Gleich - nis;
das Un - zu - läng - li - che, hier wirds Er - eig - nis;

'eternal blessedness' [ewige Seligkeit], and I cannot do better than employ this beautiful and sufficient mythology [mythologischen Vorstellung] – the most complete conception to which at this epoch of humanity it is possible to attain.³³

Although this letter was written three years after the completion of the Eighth, one may read in his analysis a kind of 'programme note' to the second part of the Eighth.³⁴ In Mahler's mind *Faust* and Christian imagery were interconnected;

33 Alma Mahler, *Gustav Mahler: Memories and Letters*, ed. Donald Mitchell, trans. Basil Creighton (New York: Viking, 1969), 320–21. Original in Alma Mahler-Werfel and Gustav Mahler, *Erinnerungen an Gustav Mahler: Briefe an Alma Mahler*, ed. Donald Mitchell (Frankfurt a. M.: Ullstein, 1980), 351–3. This passage was written three years after the completion of the Eighth, possibly because the intervening traumatic events in Mahler's life (between 1906 and 1910, the year of the premiere of the Eighth) triggered a re-examination of the Symphony's spiritual message. They should in no way, however, serve as documentation of the *original* inspiration behind the work. They constitute events *ex post facto*, and should be viewed as such.

34 Mahler's views on *Faust* were probably shaped early on when, as a student in Vienna, he met the poet and philosopher Siegfried Lipiner (1856–1911). Even though Lipiner's dissertation on *Faust* (*Homunculus: Eine Studie über Faust und die Philosophie Goethes*, Vienna, 1894) is now lost, Mahler shared his philosophical ideas and artistic beliefs. See William J. McGrath,

just as in Goethe before, they served as a mythic anchor, a system of symbols and values that transcended beyond themselves.

A Mass in Symphonic Dress

Mahler's musical setting constitutes an analogue to the uncompromising qualities inherent in Goethe's drama. *Faust*, a quintessential example of *genera mixta*, helped lend the Symphony its heterogeneous make-up. The Eighth traverses traditional generic boundaries. It is a Symphony in name only – a 'host' genre whose markers guarantee its communicatory meaning.³⁵ As such, it betrays a conscious approach on the part of the composer to integrate symphonic principles of tonal and formal organization (both parts may be analyzed as large sonata-form structures). It is also a 'Choral' Symphony, since Mahler uses voices not only sporadically, but throughout. Its combination of a sacred hymn and a quasi-religious text has prompted many writers to interpret the Symphony in its entirety as a religious statement. From its unconventional pairing of *Veni creator spiritus* and *Faust* to the use of multiple vocal forces, the work has often been characterized as a motet, a cantata, an oratorio,³⁶ a religious drama in the tradition of *Parsifal*³⁷ and even a meta-opera.³⁸ Carl Dahlhaus includes the second part of the Eighth – together with Felix Mendelssohn's Symphony-Cantata no. 2, the *Lobgesang* (1838–40), Hector Berlioz's Dramatic Symphony *Roméo et Juliette* (1839) and Liszt's *Eine Faust-Symphonie* – in a discrete category he calls 'Symphonische Kantate'. This genre constitutes an amalgamation of two different genres whose characteristics are not merely juxtaposed, but rather fused into one.³⁹ Similarly, H.F. Redlich associated the Eighth with 'ecclesiastical choral music and with oratorio'. Part I, he contended,

Dionysian Art and Populist Politics in Austria (New Haven and London: Yale University Press, 1974); Caroline A. Kita, 'Jacob Struggling with the Angel: Siegfried Lipiner, Gustav Mahler, and the Search for Aesthetic-Religious Redemption in Fin-de-siècle Vienna', PhD Thesis (Duke University, 2011), 218–20; Stephen Hefling, 'Siegfried Lipiner's *On the Elements of a Renewal of Religious Ideas in the Present*', in *Mahler im Kontext / Contextualizing Mahler*, ed. Erich Wolfgang Partsch and Morten Solvik (Vienna: Böhlau, 2011), 91–114.

35 The term 'host' is used by Jeffrey Kallberg, 'The Rhetoric of Genre: Chopin's Nocturne in G Minor', *19th Century Music* 11/3 (1988), 238–61.

36 de La Grange, *Gustav Mahler*, vol. 3, 890.

37 Constantin Floros, *Gustav Mahler: The Symphonies*, trans. Vernon Wicker (Portland, OR: Amadeus Press, 1993), 227.

38 Michael P. Steinberg, *Austria as Theater and Ideology: The Meaning of the Salzburg Festival* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2000), 214.

39 Carl Dahlhaus, 'Zur Problematik der musikalischen Gattungen im 19. Jahrhundert', in *Gattungen der Musik in Einzeldarstellungen, Gedenkschrift Leo Schrade*, ed. Wulf Arlt, Ernst Lichtenhahn and Hans Oesch (Munich: Francke, 1973), 878; cf. Dahlhaus, *Nineteenth-Century Music*, trans. J. Bradford Robinson (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1989), 164–5; John Daverio, *Nineteenth-Century Music and the German Romantic Ideology* (New York: Schirmer, 1993), 129–31. Hermann Danuser views the work as a synthesis of oratorio, symphonic form, and dramatic form, in 'Der Goethe-Interpret Mahler: Zur Achten Symphonie als Weltanschauungsmusik', *Musik & Wetenschap: Dutch Journal for Musicology* 5 (1995–6), 266–85.

'comes far closer to religious choral music of symphonic proportions, such as Bruckner's Masses and *Te Deum*, than to symphony proper'.⁴⁰

The result is a work whose compositional ethos encodes the Symphony with multiple generic markers, primarily those associated with sacred *topoi*. Mahler himself acknowledged its religious orientation when he reportedly called the Eighth Symphony his 'Mass'. This reference appears in *Die Bildnisse von Gustav Mahler*, a book of pictures with a prologue written by the stage designer Alfred Roller. Mahler had collaborated with Roller on many opera productions that the composer conducted during his tenure as Director of the Court Opera in Vienna. Roller's account implies apprehension on Mahler's part at the prospect of composing music for the Credo of a Mass, perhaps because of its doctrinal implications:

Ich fragte ihn einst, warum er eigentlich keine Messe schreibe. [...] 'Nein, das vermag ich doch nicht.' Aber nach einer Probe der 'Achten' in München rief er mir in Erinnerung an dieses Gespräch fröhlich zu: 'Sehen Sie, das ist meine Messe.'⁴¹

[Once I asked him, why he didn't actually write a Mass. [...] 'No, that I can't do'. But, after a rehearsal of the Eighth in Munich, he reminded me of that conversation, calling out cheerfully: 'Look, this is my Mass'.]⁴²

Mahler's 'Mass' transcends dogmas. It treats Bible and literature alike, as mythopoeic repositories of knowledge, culture, philosophy and eschatology.⁴³ By Mahler's time *Faust* had attained the status of canonical text. Heinrich Heine's famous dictum that Goethe's *Faust* had become 'die weltliche Bibel der Deutschen'⁴⁴ [the secular Bible of the Germans] exemplified a duality that continued to persist: secular texts could be revered as highly as any excerpt from the Bible, and thus treated in a manner that would fuse secular interpretation with quasi-religious reverence. *Faust's* universality spoke to Mahler's artistic vision. As Bruno Walter reported,

Nothing was nearer to his heart than this appeal, entreaty, and challenge by humanity, and what joy it was for him that there was an answer such as Goethe's promise [...]. He could not tell me enough about the happiness he had experienced in surrendering himself so entirely to Goethe's words, and in being able so profoundly to identify himself with them. And yet, this is his

40 Hans Ferdinand Redlich, *Bruckner and Mahler* (London: Dent, 1963), 214.

41 Alfred Roller, *Die Bildnisse von Gustav Mahler* (Leipzig: E.P. Tal, 1922), 26.

42 Translation adapted from de La Grange, *Gustav Mahler*, vol. 3, 461–2.

43 This is also the conception of myth and mythology that derives from nineteenth-century German Christian history. See George S. Williamson, *The Longing for Myth in Germany* (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2004).

44 Heinrich Heine, *Die romantische Schule* (Halle a.d. Saale: Otto Hendel, [n.d.]), 36; trans. Helen Mustard in *The Romantic School and Other Essays*, ed. Jost Hermand and Robert C. Holub (New York: Continuum, 1985), 40.

most 'objective' work. It is not Mahler, but all mankind which sings this hymn and receives the consolation of the second movement.⁴⁵

Perhaps Mahler saw Faust as the manifestation of the modern, post-Christian human whose quest 'is both self-fulfilling and self-defeating', as Nicholas Boyle has suggested.⁴⁶ In that sense, Christian myth transmutes into *Kunstreligion* and thereby Mahler emerges as a modern man whose art becomes his personal post-Christian 'credo'.⁴⁷

Perhaps in 1906 Mahler did not set out to write a symphony the spirit of which would resemble that of a sacred mass. By 1910, however, the year of its premiere in Munich, he possibly recognized this work as his spiritual testament. The Eighth Symphony is not a statement of metaphysical agony (as was his Second Symphony, 'The Resurrection'), but of affirmation. The optimism unequivocally expressed in several of Mahler's letters and statements is also expressed in the music's monumentality. Adorno's dismissal of the Eighth as the 'mißglückte, objektiv unmögliche Wiederbelebung des kultischen' [aborted, objectively impossible resuscitation of the cultic] speaks more about the philosopher's own apprehension toward glorification of the collective than about Mahler's ineffectiveness.⁴⁸

Social critic and philosopher Ernst Bloch saw Mahler as the embodiment of the spirit of Goethe's poetry, and his setting of *Faust* as the *non plus ultra* of such an artistic endeavour. In his first major work, *Geist der Utopie* [The Spirit of Utopia, 1918; revised in 1923],⁴⁹ Bloch lamented the decline of performances of Mahler's symphonic music – a result, in his view, of the audience's lack of ability to comprehend it. Bloch concluded his dithyrambic note on Mahler thus:

niemand ist bisher in der Gewalt seelenvollster, rauschendster, visionärster Musik dem Himmel nähergetragen worden als dieser sehnsuchtsvolle, heilige, hymnenhafte Mann. Das Herz bricht auf vor dem 'Ewig, ewig', vor dem Urlicht tief innen; wie ein ferner Bote kam dieser Künstler in seine leere, matte, skeptische Zeit, erhaben in der Gesinnung, unerhört in der Kraft und männlichen Glut seines Pathos, und wahrhaft nahe daran, das letzte Geheimnis der Musik über Welt und Gräbern zu spenden.⁵⁰

45 Bruno Walter, 'Mahlers Weg, ein Erinnerungsblatt', *Der Merker* 3 (1911), 166–71; trans. in de La Grange, *Gustav Mahler*, vol. 3, 430.

46 See Nicholas Boyle, 'Wagering on Modernity', in this volume, 60.

47 See Constantin Floros's discussion of the Eighth and the idea of *Kunstreligion* in 'Die "Symphonie der Tausend" als Botschaft an die Menschheit', in *A 'Mass' for the Masses*, 121.

48 Theodor W. Adorno, *Mahler: Eine musikalische Physiognomik* (Frankfurt a. M.: Suhrkamp, 1960), 182, and *Mahler: A Musical Physiognomy*, trans. Edmund Jephcott (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1992), 138.

49 Although Bloch's philosophy betrays ties to the Marxist camp, at the time of the book's publication he 'was still far from being a dyed-in-the-wool Marxist'; see Benjamin B. Korstvedt, *Listening for Utopia in Ernst Bloch's Musical Philosophy* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), 24.

50 Ernst Bloch, *Geist der Utopie* (Frankfurt a. M.: Suhrkamp, 1971), 123.

[No one had ever been carried closer to Heaven under the power of soulful, surging, visionary music than this yearning, holy, hymnic man. One's heart bursts at the 'Ewig, ewig', at the primordial light deep inside; like a messenger from afar this artist came into his empty, weary, skeptical age, noble of temperament, unprecedented in the power and virile fervor of his emotion, and truly on the verge of bestowing music's final mystery on the world and over every grave.]⁵¹

In Bloch's terms there is a utopian impulse in this work that acts as a harbinger of the future. The outcome is a work *sui generis*, Mahler's answer to his relationship with nature and metaphysics, the mundane and the divine, the human and the transcendental. Just as the Eighth opens with a grand invocation to the *dimiourgon* Spirit (especially the motif E flat-B flat-A flat, Example 11.10), so it ends with the triumphant reiteration of the same theme in the brass. This time, however, it points even higher musically, ascending from A flat to C (E flat-B flat-C, Example 11.11). With this allusive gesture Mahler the artist recognizes in the Creator Spirit the fountain of the work's inspiration. In his quest toward offering a metaphysical vision of Faustian redemption and salvation Mahler proposes an exegesis of *Faust* that simultaneously critiques and acknowledges its agency toward the culmination of his artistic vision.

Example 11.10 Mahler, *Symphony no. 8, Part I: 'Veni creator spiritus'*, bars 1–5.

Allegro impetuoso

ff

S A

T B

Orchestra

ff

Ven - ni, ven - ni, cre - a - tor spi - ri - tus!

Example 11.11 Mahler, *Symphony no. 8, Part II, end, bars 1560–63.*

ff

marcatissimo

51 Ernst Bloch, 'The Philosophy of Music', in *The Spirit of Utopia*, trans. Anthony A. Nassar (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2000), 67.